

Canberra is studying Tasmanian dam options

From SIMON BALDSTONE

CANBERRA. — The Federal Government is studying alternatives to the Gordon-below-Franklin dam scheme in south-west Tasmania as part of its responsibilities under the World Heritage Convention.

The Government appears to be heading towards a "co-operative" approach with the Tasmanian Government whereby it could fulfil its world heritage responsibilities of studying all prudent alternatives to destruction of a designated area.

Big field for Flinders preselection

From MICHELLE GRATTAN

CANBERRA. — A former Liberal member of the Victorian Parliament, Mr Jim Short, is planning to seek preselection for the marginal seat of Flinders, which is vacant following Sir Philip Lynch's retirement.

The immediate past president of the Victorian Party, Mr Richard Atkins, is also likely to be a candidate in the large field facing preselection on 31 October.

Nominations for preselection close tomorrow. The candidate list will be chosen by a convention of local branch delegates.

Flinders would be left to Labor on a two-party preferred swing of 5.2 per cent.

A pre-selection will be called for the seat which would see Mr Fraser directed to call a general election of the Victorian Liberal Party at a date yet to be determined.

Mr Short, who was defeated at the 1980 election, is now general manager of the Victorian Liberal Party.

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Even guide dogs at risk in robot invasion

From STEPHEN MILLS

CANBERRA. — With dogs quoted lengthening around the nation, a Government report has detected yet another threat to Australian jobs — robots.

The report, released yesterday, estimates that by the end of the decade there may be as many as 1400 robots whirring and clicking their way around Australian factories and offices.

As many as 4000 workers looking for new jobs as a result.

The report tabled in Federal parliament yesterday makes it clear that when it comes to new ideas in robots, Japanese scientists are streets ahead.

Certainly, Australians are working on the robot sheep shearer and the robot egg picker and other such devices.

But can they match the 26-fingered robot for detecting breast cancer which the Japanese are said to be working on? Or the guide dog robot for the blind? Or the robot shaped like a snake which is capable of probing stomachs?

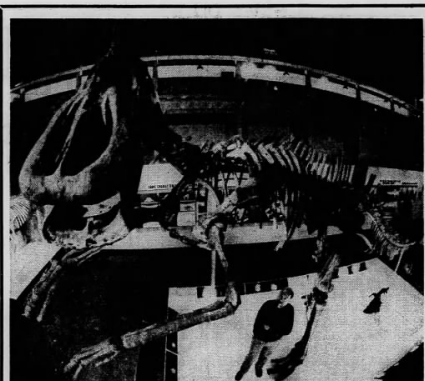
Sick people in Japanese hospitals may one day be on the road to recovery by a robot-handling robot, which can roll up to the hospital bed, stretch its arms out, and turn the patient over, or even carry a forearm-mounted scanner (unconscious) patient out to the bathroom.

Meanwhile, at the University of Western Australia, work continues on the sheep shearer, which of course, poses some problems because "they vary in shape and size and we need to be able to move and are not easy to hold", the report continues.

It is important to recognise that technological innovation in manufacturing is essential to the survival of a country, and that failure to innovate may mean a country's loss of competitive edge in the marketplace, they report.

These circumstances may be greater than would result from labor-saving technology.

The word robot was coined in 1921 by the playwright Karel Capek in his play "Rossum's Universal Robots".



The biggest children's craze in Melbourne during the next few months has suddenly become easy to predict. Hardly a household will escape the sight of "Mummy, can we go and see the dinosaurs?"

Mr Traynor and Dino's bones

Dinosaur skeletons bound to be a hit

Lahey at Large

The National Museum negotiated the loan of the dinosaur from the Chinese and the Chinese authorities, and the chief presenter, Mr Traynor, went to Japan to study the skeletons.

Mr Traynor said that a song kept coming through their minds. "The know-how connected to the dinosaurs, the alpha-bone connected to the hipbone."

Unfortunately, the significance of the song was lost on a group of Chinese who had come to Australia.

Car sales plummet to lowest for year

By IAN PORTER

New vehicle sales plunged 11.6 per cent in September to their lowest level for the year, finishing the car industry's run as the one bright spot in the national economy.

The slump in sales was recorded despite some unusual moves by GM dealers who registered more than 2000 un-sold Holden cars to try to help GM's retail market leadership for the 30th straight year.

Without these extra GM registrations, September car sales would have dropped more than 15 per cent, an alarming fall even though the industry was expecting a decline last month.

Lower demand was expected after heavy discount campaigns and new car launches in July and August. These factors also hurt sales forward, leaving late months looking weak.

Increasing uncertainty about employment and the continuation of interest rates at high levels through September also thought to have adversely influenced demand.

Sales in New South Wales, the country's biggest vehicle market, were also depressed by an industry dispute in September, the petrol tanker drivers' strike.

The 4003 vehicles registered in September represented an average of 250 units a day. This was 11.6 per cent below the August average of 281 units a day.

The decline in September was even under the traditionally slow start of the new year.

The registration figures are compiled each month by the Motor Vehicle Industry Association.

People at the museum, which is particularly busy, are cooking up the most, because displays are as scarce as dinosaurs.

The museum is making the most of it to be taken by its achievement that it has produced a record of a children's song called "Gee, I'd like to see a dinosaur".

The record will be on sale at the door. And to feed the car crash still further, children can also get dinosaur placemats — free. Dinosaurs are plentiful all over the display area.

The Premier, Mr Cain, who will open the three-month display today, probably has no idea what untold forces he is unleashing.

Fortunate little Mammals: Mammals' feet are a big thing that when two plaster casts of them are put side by side, they become as white as a crash that can comfortably seat three people.

JOHN LAHEY.

Dingoes attacked children at Rock, court told

From LINDSAY MURDOCH

DARWIN. — Dingoes at Ayers Rock had attacked children about the time of Azaria Chamberlain's disappearance in 1980, the Northern Territory Supreme Court was told yesterday.

John Anthony Cornack, of Singapore, told the court that in July 1980 while his family was camped at Ayers Rock a dingo attacked his son, Paul, who was then almost four.

Mr Cornack said he heard Paul scream and turned to see a dingo standing over his son, who was lying flat on his back.

Mr Cornack said he saw four paw prints on either side of his son who suffered a big scalp laceration.

Mrs Chamberlain West of Singapore, Azaria's mother, told the court that she saw a dingo attack her family at Ayers Rock in August.

Ms West said that the evening before Azaria disappeared (Sunday 17 August) she was sitting on a bench when a dingo barked at her.

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